RESEARCH

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EMEA Macro Snapshot

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BoE Post view: Rates on Hold Amid Complex Scenarios

In a divided **8-1** vote, the Bank of England (BoE) left its interest rates unchanged at **3.75%**, though Chief Economist Huw Pill dissented, favouring a modest rate hike earlier than later. The BoE's economic outlook is shaped by the Iran war's energy shock and the risk of persistent second-round inflation effects, necessitating a state-contingent policy response. Scenarios A, B, and C explore outcomes ranging from a short-lived shock to a prolonged surge in energy prices, with Scenario C potentially requiring forceful monetary tightening. Despite noting "a good deal of space available to accommodate" current pressures, Governor Bailey acknowledged the difficult judgment call, warning against delayed action. A weaker economy is expected to eventually curb inflation, but the potential for second-round effects and the uncertainty surrounding the energy shock's duration underscore the MPC's complex task.

Our central scenario now assumes the conflict lasts one month longer – with a gradual end of the Hormuz strait blockade by the summer – than previously projected, with gas prices less affected than oil prices. Despite this, we foresee two rate hikes later this year, likely in the second half (July and November), to counter increased inflation expectations and insufficient labour market softening to contain wage demands.

A « difficult judgment call »

In an **8-1** vote, the committee decided to keep interest rates unchanged, a decision that followed March's unanimous vote to hold rates steady.

Recognizing that a weaker economy and labour market will temper inflation, the BoE has provided forecasts based on three energy price scenarios, acknowledging the significant impact of the shock's size and duration. This approach replaces a single central projection.

Scenario A assumes energy prices follow futures curves, with households prioritizing saving and causing demand weakness stronger than historical income relationships suggest; this short-lived energy shock and weak demand are expected to prevent second-round inflation effects. **Scenario B** projects similar energy price peaks but sustained higher levels than A, with household saving behaviour aligning with historical norms and only modest second-round effects. **Scenario C** anticipates a sharp, prolonged rise in energy prices, leading to significantly stronger second-round inflation effects than in Scenario B. The most inflationary scenario C would necessitate forceful monetary policy tightening, with projections indicating a peak inflation of 6.2% in Q1 2027 if rates only follow market expectations.

Economic forecasts under different scenarios:

- The BoE expects CPI inflation to rise this year, driven by higher energy price pass-through. Their forecast range for 2026 CPI is 3.3%-4.5% (compared to February's central projection of 2.2%.), with 2027 CPI averaging 2.6%-4.8% (up from 1.9%), and 2028 CPI at 1.5%-2.9% (compared to 2%).

- GDP growth forecasts have also been lowered to 0.7%-0.8% for 2026 (down from February's central scenario of 0.9%) and 0.8%-1.0% for 2027 (from 1.5%).

Conference:

Governor Andrew Bailey describing the decision as a "difficult judgment call" due to the Iran war's energy shock and the risk of second-round inflation effects. He warned against waiting for conclusive evidence before acting, stating it would be "too late," but also indicated "a good deal of space available to accommodate" current pressures without immediate hikes. While he sees space to "accommodate" current pressures, Bailey acknowledged a prolonged energy spike (Scenario C) could necessitate a "forceful" rate hike, and gave no "cast iron assurance" against future increases, stressing the need for judgment at every meeting rather than waiting for definitive data on second-round inflation effects. The BoE highlighted indirect impacts on food prices as likely largest due to energy intensity, and risks of second-round effects on wages and prices from inflation expectations and firms passing on costs. However, a weaker economy and labour market are expected to temper these pressures over time. Governor Andrew Bailey indicated that interest rates are currently "not in the wrong place," suggesting there's "space available to accommodate" current inflation pressures without immediate hikes. Bailey considers Scenario B the most plausible for energy prices, describing today's hold as "active," not passive, and emphasizing that conclusive data on pay growth, which will take time to emerge due to agreed annual settlements, is still pending.

MPC Divided Amidst Energy Shock & Inflation Persistence Fears

MPC members acknowledge the Iran war-induced energy shock presents upside upside inflation risks, potentially leading to persistent second-round effects on wages and prices. While a weaker economy and tighter financial conditions are expected to moderate inflation over time, views diverge on the immediate policy response and the scale of these risks.

- **Governor Andrew Bailey** emphasizes a balanced approach, considering growth and jobs alongside inflation. He views current policy as restrictive enough for a **"wait and see"** stance, highlighting the difficulty of an immediate rate hike due to energy price volatility, although he acknowledges upside inflation risks (leaning towards Scenario B with reduced second-round effects).

- **Chief Economist Huw Pill** argues for proactive inflation control, criticizing the "wait-and-see" approach. He feels current restrictive policy may be insufficient given the potential for self-sustaining inflation and the structural shift in price/wage setting. He advocates for a prompt, modest rate hike to mitigate upside inflation risks, prioritizing price stability and noting monetary policy cannot engineer "real adjustments" to permanent shocks.

- **MPC Member Greene** sees significant upside inflation risks from energy shocks and second-round effects as paramount, favouring action over waiting for definitive data, cautioning that waiting too long could be detrimental. She leans towards inflation between Scenarios B and C, likely requiring a tighter monetary stance, and believes an increase may be necessary soon.

- **MPC Member Breeden**, however, sees less risk of entrenched second-round effects than in 2022 due to a weaker labour market and current rate restrictiveness. She views current restrictive policy as sufficient to guard against second-round effects and awaits further data, placing most weight on Scenario B.

- **MPC Member Dhingra** notes the inflation outlook risks have shifted upwards, with scenarios A, B, and C all plausible. She emphasizes that labour market slack and weak demand should limit second-round effects under Scenario B but acknowledges a sharper policy trade-off would be needed for larger, longer energy shocks, with a limit on acceptable output loss.

- **MPC Member Lombardelli** acknowledges the disruption but sees lingering domestic inflationary pressures and heightened consumer/business sensitivity to price rises. She also favors Scenario B, seeing it as more realistic, but would respond forcefully if Scenario C materialized. She believes tightening financial conditions are warranted and holding rates provides appropriate restrictiveness while more data emerges.

- **MPC Member Mann** believes scenarios might overestimate disinflationary slack and underestimate firms' pricing power. She sees greater second-round effects than scenarios suggest, pointing to embedded inflation into 2027 via wage bargaining. She favours an "active hold" to gather more data but would expect to increase Bank Rate if inflation continues to rise.

- **MPC Member Ramsden** acknowledges upside inflation risks from the energy shock but also downside risks from weakening demand. He sees second-round effects as likely limited by labour market slack and subdued demand. He favours holding rates currently due to uncertainty, but would consider a hike under Scenario B and reacts forcefully if Scenario C materialized.

- **MPC Member Taylor** compares the current shock to 2011, noting a weak economy and early signs of cost pass-through. He believes second-round effects are unlikely to be quickly evident due to wage settlements and emphasizes a state-contingent strategy, weighing supply shocks, policy costs, and credibility. He favours holding rates and a neutral or accommodative stance post-conflict, finding current restrictive financial conditions adequate insurance against risks.

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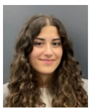

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